Early Entry to Kindergarten

jcolby11@hevanet.com <jcolby11@hevanet.com> Thu, Oct 27, 2022 at 9:22 PM
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To: PPS Board of Directors, Deputy Superintendent of Instruction & School Communities Dr. Cheryl Proctor, Chief Academic Officer Dr. Kimberlee Armstrong, Director of Early Learners Angelica Cruz, Senior Director Pk-5 Core Academics Emily Glasgow, Senior Director of Academic Programs Dana Nerenberg

Re: Early Entry to Kindergarten (EE to K)

The EE to K application process and its challenges and inequities have been a topic of ongoing discussion between TAGAC and PPS' 3 recent TAG directors. The impression we (and they) have had is that a policy change was either impossible or outside the TAG director's purview. Because of this, we are excited to have an opportunity to weigh in on this process. It absolutely needs to change.

During the policy meeting, Senior Director Emily Glasgow noted that the EE to K process had been transferred from the TAG department to Early Learners because it is not a TAG service. We strongly disagree. It is, in fact, one of only a handful of consistent services available within PPS that meets both the rate and level of Highly Capable and Accelerated Learners (HC/AL). EE to K is a service for HC/AL students for whom another year of Pre-K or no school at all would be counterproductive. We recognize that this is a pathway suitable only for a subset of PPS students. However, it is still vital; every student matters, and every student deserves an education that meets their needs.

Further, eliminating EE to K will not impact the inequities of access. Parents with the time, knowledge, and privilege will do what any number already do - enroll their child early in a private kindergarten and enter PPS at 1st grade.

Our goal for changing this policy is to remove barriers and introduce culturally competent assessments, so as to best center students, most importantly Historically Underserved students. BIPOC students are most likely to be under supported in their learning due to early educational inequity. Denial of the opportunity to enter kindergarten early further disadvantages the very students we seek to lift up; identifying and supporting these students is crucial to ensure they are not identified as "problems" because they're frustrated and acting out (or ignoring a teacher, or not doing the work, or any of the myriad ways HC/AL kids express their frustration). It is well known that BIPOC students, particularly Black students, because of institutional racism and white supremacist structures, are far more likely to be seen as "making trouble" and experience disproportionate discipline.

To this end, we propose a new EE to K process that works towards full inclusivity and ensures social and emotional readiness:

- Post the application process on both the Pre-K and TAG department web pages
- Begin the process with a parent questionnaire
  - Allow input from pediatricians, who assess their patient's capabilities regularly
- Institute culturally competent assessments with multiple metrics - see examples below
- Fund students whose families cannot afford assessment fees
- Assess social emotional readiness with appropriate, culturally relevant metrics - see examples below
- Develop an in-school support plan to monitor and aid the child's success.

We have included articles regarding the Black and Brown Gifted experience for your reference:

WaPo: On Parenting - What I've Learned About Raising Children Who Are Young, Gifted, and Black

https://www.washingtonpost.com/lifestyle/2021/07/08/gifted-black-child/

Global#Gchat Powered by TAGT: Supporting Gifted ELLs in the Latinx Community

https://globalgtchatpoweredbytagt.word

press.com/2022/03/01/supporting-gifted-ells-in-the-latinx-community/

NPR: The Rare District That Recognizes the Gifted Latino Students

https://www.npr.org/sections/ed/2016/03/31/472528190/the-rare-district-that-recognizes-gifted-latino-students

AmericanProgress.org: Top 5 Ways for Public Schools to Better Support Talented Students of Color

https://www.americanprogress.org/article/top-5-ways-for-public-schools-to-better-support-talented-students-of-color/

NAGC: Nurturing Gifted African American Children

https://docs.google.com/document/d/1l66e3TQIGs6CO8dNdgBMFuvrHgNhbd9LMpA29aL-ii8/edit?usp=sharing

Standing in the Gaps: Examining the Effects of Early Gifted Education on Black Girl Achievement in STEM

https://docs.google.com/document/d/1UylLYNRR8SR6N57m4SMgZX527erfPv0cssri7FSFAmg/edit?usp=sharing

A Culturally Responsive Equity Based Bill of Rights for Students Of Color

https://docs.google.com/document/d/1SRmgbSfP_BwA-DzAxMOr3bnsGqXjZJRiVcegpOfcf0s/edit?usp=sharing

Thank you,

Jessica Colby, TAGAC chair

Below are assessment resources and further literature supporting early access, found in the Colorado Dept. of Education's Early Access for Highly Advanced Gifted Children under Age Six handbook.

https://www.cde.state.co.us/gt/earlyaccess2016rev

Commonly Used Assessments for Early Access

Note: The Office of Gifted Education does not select or approve gifted identification assessments. This is a list of commonly used assessments for Early Access. For data to be valid and reliable, it is important to use the most current assessment edition.

Aptitude			
Name	***Age***	***Administration***	***Contact***
Cognitive Abilities (CogAT)	K-12	Group	Riverside Publishing, riversidepublishing.com, 800.323.9540
Naglieri Nonverbal Ability Test (NNAT)	K-12	Group	Pearson, pearsonassessments.com, 800.627.7271
Batería Woodcock Muñoz (Cognitive)	2:0 – 90+	Individual – In Spanish	Riverside Publishing, riversidepublishing.com, 800.323.9540
Battelle Developmental Inventory (BDI)	Birth to 7:11	Individual	Riverside Publishing, riversidepublishing.com, 800.323.9540
Bilingual Verbal Abilities Test (BVAT)	5:0 – Adult	Individual	Riverside Publishing, riversidepublishing.com, 800.323.9540
Differential Ability Scales (DAS)	2:6-17:11	Individual	Pearson, pearsonassessments.com, 800.627.7271
Kaufman Assessment Battery for Children (KABC)	3:0-18	Individual	Pearson, pearsonassessments.com, 800.627.7271
Kaufman Brief Intelligence Test (K-BIT)	4:0 -90:0		Pearson, pearsonassessments.com, 800.627.7271
Stanford Binet Intelligence Scales (SB)	2 to 85 + years	Individual	Riverside Publishing, riversidepublishing.com, 800.323.9540
Universal Nonverbal Intelligence Test (UNIT)	5:0 – 17:11	Individual	Riverside Publishing, riversidepublishing.com, 800.323.9540
Wechsler Preschool and Primary Scale of Intelligence (WPPSI)	2:6 – 7:3	Individual	Pearson, pearsonassessments.com, 800.627.7271
Woodcock Johnson Tests of Cognitive Abilities, Brief Intellectual Ability	2:0 – 90+	Individual	Riverside Publishing, riversidepublishing.com, 800.323.9540

Commonly Used Assessments for Early Access, continued

Achievement			
Name	***Age***	***Administration***	***Contact***
Test of Early Mathematics Ability (TEMA)	Ages 3-0 through 8-11	Individual	PRO-ED, Inc., proedinc.com 800-897-3202
Test of Early Reading Ability (TERA)	Ages 3-6 through 8-6	Individual	PRO-ED, Inc., proedinc.com 800-897-3202
Test of Early Written Language (TEWL)	Ages 4-0 through 11-11	Individual	PRO-ED, Inc., proedinc.com 800-897-3202
Wechsler Individual Achievement Test	4:0–50:11	Individual	Pearson, pearsonassessments.com, 800.627.7271
Woodcock-Johnson Normative Update (NU) Tests of Achievement, Forms A and B	2 to 90+	Individual	Houghton Mifflin Harcourt - Riverside, 800.323.9540; riversidepublishing.com

Performance			
Name	***Age***	***Administration***	***Contact***
Gifted Evaluation Scales (GES)	5:0-18:0	Teacher Rating Form	Hawthorne Educational Services, Inc., hawthorne-ed.com, 800.542.1673
Gifted Rating Scales - Preschool (GRS-P)	4:0 through 6:11 years	Teacher Rating Form	Pearson, pearsonassessments.com 800.627.7271
Scales for Identifying Gifted Students (SIGS)	Ages 5-18	Teacher Rating Form	Prufrock Press, http://www.prufrock.com/ 800.998.2208
Kingore Observation Inventory, 4th Edition (KOI)	K-8	Teacher Rating Form	Professional Associates Publishing, kingore.com
Work Sampling via classroom performance or student portfolio			

Commonly Used Assessments for Early Access, continued

School Readiness – Approved for Colorado			
Name	***Age***	***Administration***	***Contact***
The Desired Results Developmental Profile for Kindergarten (DRDP-K)	Grade K	Teacher observation	Center for Child & Family Studies at WestEd, 800.770.6339 drdpk.org
The Riverside Early Assessment of Learning	Birth to 7:11	Teacher observation and assessment	Houghton Mifflin Harcourt - Riverside, 800.323.9540; riversidepublishing.com
Teaching Strategies Gold	Birth - K	Individual	Teaching Strategies for Early Childhood, 800.637.3652 teachingstrategies.com
Teaching Strategies Gold Survey – Kindergarten Entry Assessment	Grade K	Teacher questionnaire	Teaching Strategies for Early Childhood, 800.637.3652 teachingstrategies.com

Acceleration Guidelines			
Name	***Age***	***Administration***	***Contact***
Iowa Acceleration Scale	K - 8	Team completion	Great Unlimited, LLC 520-715-6306 https://www.giftedunlimitedllc.com/

Literature Supporting Early Access

Assouline, S., Colangelo, N., & VanTassel-Baska, J. (2015). *A Nation Empowered*. Iowa City, IA: Belin-Blank Center.

Hertzog, N. (2008). *Early Childhood Gifted Education*. (Gifted Child Education Practical Strategies Series). Waco, TX: Prufrock Press.

Porter, L. (2005). *Gifted Young Children: A Guide for Teachers and Parents.* Maidenhead, UK: Open University Press.

Smutney, J., Walker, S. & Honeck, E. (2016). *Teaching Gifted Children in Today's Preschool and Primary Classrooms: Identifying, Nurturing and Challenging Children Ages 4 – 9.* Minneapolis, MN: Free Spirt Publishing.

Smutney, J., & von Fremd, S. E. (2010). *Differentiating for the Young Child: Teaching Strategies Across the Content Areas PreK-3, Second Edition*. Thousand Oaks, CA: Corwin Press.